

Mishra's relationship with Shivraj Chouhan has been strained in the present term, so much so that his trip to Delhi led to rumours of an imminent CM change

issues, he is taking a calculated risk and also trying to endear himself to the Sangh. One must understand that people in other parties outside the state don't know him. With new controversies, he thinks they will soon enough."

Hailing from a political family, Mishra has always been a "colourful personality". He cut his teeth in student politics in Gwalior and was elected as an MLA from the region's Dabra segment in 1990. He lost the next election in a triangular fight, but was re-elected in 1998. After Dabra was declared a reserved constituency in 2008, Mishra shifted to the Datia seat, from where he has won three elections.

In Bhopal, where he spends his weekdays, Mishra lives in the exclusive hilly locality of Char Imli. Once it was home only to top civil servants, but ministers, MLAs and even journalists also live there now. Mishra goes for a walk in the evening with his boisterous entourage, much to the chagrin of the senior officers' wives, who grumble about the political class and their hangers-on for having 'encroached' on genteel Char Imli—something they can do little about. Otherwise wary of whom he meets, Mishra does have a group of journalists hanging around his house in anticipation of the sound bites he so regularly dispenses. He is also said to be fanatical about his post-lunch siesta, letting nothing come in its way.

Weekends are reserved for his constituency where Mishra is known to be very accessible to voters. He is also among the few MP cabinet ministers who answer their phones personally.

While in the opposition in the 1990s, Mishra very soon attracted attention for his fiery interventions in House proceedings, especially during debates. He was known for his oratory and was first appointed a minister in mid-2005 by Babulal Gaur and retained by Chouhan in his maiden cabinet in November 2005. The two enjoyed a good rapport till the end of Chouhan's first term in 2008. Mishra was always by his side, and was even described as Chouhan's "*sankatmochak* (trouble-shooter)" when the latter came under scrutiny for the 2006 'Dumper Scam' in which he allegedly spent Rs 2 crore on the equipment, a sum disproportionate to the income stated in his poll affidavit. Back then, whenever anyone asked Mishra how he was doing, he would respond with, "*Mai* (the deity at Datia's Peetambara peeth) *aur bhai* (Chouhan), *donon ka aashirwad hai* (I have the blessings of both)." Mishra contested the 2009 Lok Sabha election against Jyotiraditya Scindia in Guna but lost. He continued as minister, heading a host of departments till 2018 when the BJP was voted out of power.

In 2019, the Kamal Nath-led Congress government pursued the e-tendering scam in which the MP State Electronic Development Corporation's e-tendering software was hacked. The Rs 3,000 crore imbroglio led to the arrest of Mishra's personal staff and speculation that he too would soon be behind bars. Unfazed, Mishra was back in government as home minister soon after Madhavrao Scindia and his Congress cohorts switched sides and joined the BJP in March 2020. As expected, the police officer investigating the scam was sent on an obscure posting. Mishra has also been quite ruthless with political rivals in his constituency.

However, Mishra's relationship with Chouhan has been strained this term, so much so that a visit to Delhi on January 2 ignited speculation of an imminent change of CM. Mishra's stature in the current government is clearly higher than he has ever enjoyed as cabinet minister. He has an ADG rank IPS officer in his staff, a privilege that even the CM doesn't have. BJP insiders suggest that Mishra was a serious contender for chief ministership when the party returned to power given his vital behind-the-scenes role in destabilising the Kamal Nath government. But since he was denied the top job, Chouhan was told Mishra would have to be treated better than the average cabinet minister. Mishra used that clout to pull off transfers and postings for his kith and kin but things changed after Chouhan cemented his position following a series of byelection wins.

Within the BJP, Mishra is said to be close to Union home minister Amit Shah, although how much of it is true and how much a legend of his creation is anyone's guess. Given the party's current preoccupation with OBC (Other Backward Class) politics, Mishra's Brahmin background may well be a disqualification. But the accident of birth does not have to be an impediment to his ambition for the top job. ■